

the most feature-rich MSN Web messenger service though, and we're not surprised. Microsoft would obviously be the most qualified to build and integrate its own services into a Web browser interface. Apart from chatting (obviously), you can also access your e-mail, add contacts, search the Web, etc. Overall, if you use only MSN messenger to keep in touch with family, friends and colleagues, look no further than MSN's Web Messenger service.

9.2.5 ICQ

ICQ is an excellent online messaging service that you can sign up for. ICQ is one of the oldest online messenger services available on the Web. Apart from the usual chat service, this site offers entry into chat rooms, communities and hobby groups so that like-minded people can get together and chat with each other. There are even games to play at this site, making it much more than a mere Web messenger service.

When you sign up for this service, you are given a number which you can use to chat with people. You can chat with other friends on ICQ or join one of the various communities or groups mentioned here and spend those leisurely hours. The communities vary based on religion, nationality, age groups, gender, etc. You can even start your own community, invite your friends and form your own online group of like-minded people. To gain brownie points, ICQ also offers you an e-mail account, which is as good as any of the other services available.

9.3 Web Albums

Are you an amateur or professional shutterbug? All of us have our fondest memories captured in stills—first steps, weddings, birthdays, graduation, etc. Now you can either choose to flood your friends and family members with e-mails and large attachments, or use Web albums. With the exponential increase in popularity of digital cameras, people are sharing more photographs than ever before. Until a few years ago, this was always via e-mail, with us sending several MBs worth of pictures to anyone who we thought might want to see them. Today, everyone uses Web albums, and